

Ultimate Guide to Winning Hackathons

I've used this exact formula to never lose a single hackathon in college.

1. Pre-Hackathon Prep (48 – 24 hrs before)

- **Choose a track early.**
 - Scan event challenges; rank them by (a) your domain interest, (b) sponsor influence/prizes, (c) judging criteria weight.
 - **Brain-storm 2-3 solid ideas per track.**
 - Use ChatGPT / Perplexity to riff 20+ prompts, then converge on the top 3 with *clear problem* → *solution* → *impact* statements.
 - **Validate with sponsors.**
 - Visit the booth and pitch your shortlist. Build whichever concept excites the *actual judge-in-the-booth*. Instant validation from the dude who's gonna end up giving you the prize.
 - **Read every API doc you'll touch.**
 - Bookmark endpoints, auth flows, quota limits.
 - Prepare sample postman calls just so you don't have to waste the bulk of your hackathon time doing the integrations.
-

2. Assemble a Balanced Team

Role	Core Responsibility	Ideal Tools
Product lead / Pitcher	Idea refinement, rubric mapping, demo	Google Docs, Keynote, Loom

Frontend dev	UI/UX	Next.js + Tailwind + Vercel v0
Backend / DevOps	API, DB schema, deployments	Express + Supabase + Vercel
ML / AI wrapper	LLM integration	OpenAI API + Perplexity (or Gemini)

No blockers, no overlap. If you're solo like me, prioritize *pitch + backend scaffolding* and lean on v0 AI for UI. Make the presentation effective as it's really impressive if you're doing it solo.

3. Lightning-Fast Build Workflow (0 – 12 hrs)

1. Scaffold UI

- Prompt v0, using the fleshed-out idea on chat as your guide.
- Download resulting mock as zip.

2. Let Cursor “digest.”

- Open repo in **Cursor**. Pause 5 min while it indexes/understands ; then start natural-language queries:
 - Query I like to run is “go through this frontend and tell ”

3. Backend in one shot

- Define DB schema in **Supabase** SQL editor.
- Paste the generated table types into types.ts
- Ask Cursor: “Create Express routes for /signup, /login, /transactions using Supabase client.”

4. Integrate sponsor APIs

- Keep to **one flagship integration** that demos well.

Time target: deploy MVP in **≤ 5 hrs** so you can polish & rehearse.

4. Leveraging AI *Smarter Than Everyone Else*

- **Prompt Engineering 101**

- Prompt engineering is the craft of framing and refining the inputs you give an AI model to get precise, useful outputs
 - Start by assigning the model a clear role (e.g., “You are an expert TypeScript engineer”)
 - State your goal (“Generate an Express route to fetch user data from Supabase”)
 - Define the desired format (“Return only valid code, no commentary”).
 - Use few-shot examples or explicit step-by-step instructions to guide the model’s reasoning, iterate on your phrasing to eliminate ambiguity, and leverage techniques like chain-of-thought prompts for complex tasks
-

5. Nail the Presentation (Last 2 hrs)

1. **Map slides to rubric bullets.**

- If scoring = *Innovation 30% · Impact 30% · Tech 20% · Demo 20%*, make one slide or spoken beat for each.

2. **Hook the room.**

- Open with a 15-second story or live poll. Audience participation → memorability.

3. **Live demo > slide deck.**

- Click path: *Login* → *Key feature* → *Wow moment* (≤ 90 sec).
- Have a pre-recorded Loom backup in case live demo goes wrong.

4. **Quantify impact.**

- “Saves SMBs 5 hrs/week and \$12k/yr.” Numbers stick.

5. **Close with the ask.**

- “We’re looking for mentorship and the \$5k prize to pilot with 3 beta users.”
-

6. Judge-Proofing Tips

- **Explain the tech simply.** Judges come from mixed backgrounds, and the simpler your explanation, the clearer an indication that you truly understand your product/the tech behind it. ALSO, YOU NEED TO CLEARLY ARTICULATE THE VALUE YOUR PRODUCT CREATES.
- **Show sponsor love.** Name-drop their API in the first minute.
- **Leave 30 sec for questions** and repeat each question before answering.